### Robert H. MacArthur



Born in Toronto, Canada, in 1930, and later relocating to Vermont in the US, Robert MacArthur originally studied mathematics. In 1957, he received his Ph.D. from Yale University for his thesis exploring ecological niches occupied by warbler species in conifer forests. MacArthur's emphasis on the importance of testing hypotheses helped transform ecology from an exclusively observational field to one that employed experimental models as well. This methodology is reflected in *The Theory of Island Biogeography*, which he coauthored with Edward O. Wilson. MacArthur received awards throughout his career, and was elected to the National Academy of Sciences in 1969. In 1972, he died of renal cancer. The Ecological Society of America awards a biennial prize in his name.

#### Key works

**1967** *The Theory of Island Biogeography*

**1971** *Geographical Ecology: Patterns in the Distribution of Species*

## Human impact

The key factors influencing the species mix on an oceanic island are its degree of isolation, how long it has been isolated, its size, the suitability of its habitat, its location relative to ocean currents, and chance arrivals (for example, organisms washed up on mats of floating vegetation). Most of these factors apply to any similar, isolated habitats, not just actual islands.